



Above Richly colored and scented mounds of saffron, paprika, and cumin for sale in the souk

Left The Jemaa el-Fna at night becomes a noisy mass of food stands, suffused with the aromas of kebabs grilling on charcoal braziers



Above The rich meat stew of tagine is cooked in a distinctive earthenware vessel with a conical lid that releases fragrant aromas when lifted

Cooking Schools

Take more than just a tagine dish home from your trip to Marrakech – there are several great cooking schools in and around the city offering workshops and courses in Moroccan cuisine, and tagine is always on the syllabus. **Kasbah Agafy** (www.kasbahagafay.com) offers outdoor cooking courses in the organic herb and vegetable garden of a beautifully renovated 150-year-old fort, 20 minutes from Marrakech. **La Maison Arabe** (see *Where to Stay*) holds half-day cooking workshops for residents and guests. **Rhodes School of Cuisine** (www.rhodeschoolofcuisine.com) runs week-long courses with luxury *riad* accommodations.

The Best Places to Eat Tagine

Restaurant Al Fassia moderate

Restaurant Al Fassia faces onto a tiny but leafy courtyard and is decorated in warm, earthy colors in a modern Moroccan style. Here, chef Halima Chab and her all-woman team prepare and serve a repertoire of tagines, with up to 13 on the menu at any one time – and all of them supreme examples of the art. They might include tender lamb with caramelized onions and pumpkin, or dates and roasted almonds; chicken with olives and preserved lemons; or *kefta* (spicy meatballs) with eggs.

Begin your meal with a selection from Al Fassia's stunning range of meze, which includes a delicious honey- and cinnamon-scented squash purée, and finish with Halima Chab's signature dessert of *b'stilla* (a filo pastry) with almonds and milk.

Founded over 20 years ago, Al Fassia was once legendary – and loved – for its no-nonsense service. Since its move to a more upmarket venue in the residential Guéliz district, the atmosphere has become more refined – but the standard of cooking undoubtedly remains one of the high points of any visit to Marrakech.

55 Boulevard Zerktouni, Guéliz, Marrakech; open noon–2:30 PM and 7:30–11 PM daily, except Tue; www.alfassia.com

Also in Marrakech

To sample a tagine as part of a fine-dining experience, try the elegant and atmospheric

La Maison Arabe (www.lamaisonarabe.com; *expensive*) or the historic **La Mamounia** hotel (www.mamounia.com; *moderate*), with its magnificent terrace on the ground floor and bar and tearoom on the top floor. And for a simple but authentic tagine, as well as a jaw-dropping view over the city, opt for the rooftop tables of popular **Chez Chegrouni** at 4–6 Jemaa el-Fna (*no telephone; inexpensive*).

Also in Morocco

Interesting regional variations on the tagine are offered around Morocco. In Fès, try

Al Firdaouss (+212 535 634 343; *moderate*).

This is one of Fès's most enchanting restaurants and serves a delicious tagine. A short walk away is the traditional **Palais Tariana** (+212 535 636 604; *expensive*).

Around the World

London's Moroccan community first started to arrive in the 1960s. Since then, Moroccan food has become increasingly available and fashionable. **Momo**, just off Regent Street (www.momoresto.com; *expensive*), is London's most famous and glam Moroccan restaurant, serving high-quality food. Also in central London, **Original Tagines** (www.original-tagines.com; *inexpensive*) serves excellent tagines in contemporary Moroccan surrounds.